Amanda!

The big idea

Amanda! by **Robin Klein** shows a young girl, Amanda, being constantly **nagged** by an adult (most likely her mother). While the instructions pour in, Amanda escapes into **daydreams** of freedom. The poem is about childhood, the need for freedom and the gap between parents and children.

Structure of the poem

The poem has **two voices**:

- **The nagging adult** (stanzas 1, 2, 4, 5, 7, 9): a stream of orders and complaints.
- **Amanda's thoughts** (stanzas 3, 6, 8), written **in brackets** — her private dream world.

The nagging

- Don't **bite your nails**; don't **hunch your shoulders**; stop **slouching** and sit up straight.
- Did you finish your **homework**? Did you **tidy your room**? Clean your **shoes**!
- Don't eat that **chocolate** — remember your **acne**! Look at me when I'm speaking to you!
- Stop **sulking**; you're always so moody. And the ironic ending: **"Anyone would think that I nagged at you, Amanda!"**

Amanda's three daydreams

Daydream	What it shows
A mermaid drifting blissfully in a **languid, emerald sea**, the only inhabitant	desire for peace, solitude and freedom from rules
An orphan roaming the street, patterning the soft dust with **hushed, bare feet**; "the silence is golden, the freedom is sweet"	she wishes for no one to boss her (though she does not really understand what being an orphan means)
Rapunzel in a tower, with no cares; she would **never let down her bright hair**	she wants to be left alone, cut off from the world

THE IRONY AT THE END

The adult says, "Anyone would think that I nagged at you" — while the whole poem is nothing but nagging. The adult does not realise that the nagging is what makes Amanda moody.

Poetic devices

- **Parentheses (brackets)** separate Amanda's inner voice.
- **Repetition** of "Amanda!" — shows constant nagging.
- **Alliteration:** "**s**top that **s**louching and **s**it up **s**traight"; "**h**ushed ... **h**air".
- **Allusion: Rapunzel** (fairy tale of a girl in a tower with long hair).
- **Metaphor:** Amanda imagines herself as a mermaid / orphan / Rapunzel.
- **Imagery:** "languid, emerald sea"; "pattern soft dust".
- **Rhyme** within Amanda's stanzas (e.g. sea/me/blissfully; street/feet/sweet).
- **Irony** in the last stanza.

AMANDA IS NOT REALLY UNHAPPY WITH HER FAMILY

She does not hate her mother; she is a normal child who wants some **space and freedom**. Avoid writing that she wants to be an orphan in the real sense.

Theme and value points

- Children need **freedom, love and understanding**, not constant correction.
- Too much nagging creates rebellion and withdrawal.
- Parents mean well (health, discipline), but the way they speak matters.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How old do you think Amanda is? (About 9–10: a school child who daydreams, worries about acne.) Who is speaking to her? Why are some stanzas in brackets? Describe Amanda's daydreams. Is Amanda sulking? What is the irony in the last stanza?

Quick recap

- Robin Klein; nagging adult vs Amanda's bracketed daydreams.
- Mermaid → orphan → Rapunzel: all images of freedom and solitude.
- Ending irony: "Anyone would think that I nagged at you".
- Theme: children's need for freedom; the generation gap.

Practice questions

1. Who is most likely speaking to Amanda in the poem?
   (a) Her teacher (b) Her friend (c) Her mother (d) Her brother
2. Why are some stanzas written in brackets?
   (a) They are less important (b) They show Amanda's private thoughts and daydreams (c) They are spoken by a teacher (d) They are stage directions
3. In her first daydream, Amanda imagines herself as
   (a) an orphan (b) Rapunzel (c) a mermaid (d) a bird
4. Why does Amanda want to be an orphan?
   (a) She hates her parents (b) She is poor (c) She imagines it as a life of freedom with nobody to nag her (d) She wants to travel abroad
5. "Rapunzel" in the poem is an example of
   (a) simile (b) onomatopoeia (c) hyperbole (d) allusion
6. The last stanza is ironic because
   (a) the adult denies nagging while doing nothing but nag (b) Amanda is not sulking (c) Amanda becomes Rapunzel (d) the adult apologises
7. Describe the three daydreams of Amanda. What do they reveal about her?

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. c 5. d 6. a 7. see notes